

OFFICIAL BOTANICAL MASTERCLASS

The Beginner's Master Guide to Flower Pressing

How to Preserve Wedding Bouquets, Garden Blooms, and Sentimental Keepsakes in Crystal-Clear Acrylic

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Welcome to the Art of Botanical Preservation

Flower pressing is more than a timeless craft—it is the art of capturing a fleeting moment in nature and transforming it into permanent, vibrant artwork. Whether you are preserving your wedding bridal bouquet, saving petals from a memorial or anniversary, or turning garden blooms into framed botanical keepsakes, pressing allows delicate petals to retain their intricate structure and vivid color for decades.

This master guide covers everything you need to achieve professional-grade results from your first press: understanding the science of moisture extraction, preparing your botanical layers, avoiding browning and mold, and finishing your pressed blooms into archival-grade framed art.

1. The Science of Botanical Preservation: Why Flowers Brown

To press flowers successfully, you must understand what happens inside plant tissue when it is flattened:

1. The Enemy is Moisture

Fresh flowers are composed of 80% to 95% water. When flower tissue is crushed without rapid moisture evacuation, trapped water breaks cell walls and triggers **enzymatic oxidation** (the same chemical reaction that turns sliced apples brown).

2. The Role of Constant, Even Pressure

Uneven pressure causes petals to wrinkle and curl. Traditional wooden presses warp under humidity and tighten unevenly with straps or center screws. **Acrylic flower presses with four-corner brass bolt clamping** deliver uniform 360-degree flat pressure, keeping every petal tissue flush against absorbent drying materials.

3. Light and Heat Factors

Flowers must dry in a cool, dark, and dry environment. Direct sunlight during the pressing phase bleaches delicate pigments (especially anthocyanins in reds, blues, and purples).

2. The Acrylic Advantage: Why Clear Plates Matter

FEATURE	TRADITIONAL WOODEN PRESS	HWABELLE ACRYLIC FLOWER PRESS
Arrangement Visibility	Blind alignment (cannot see petal shifts)	100% Transparent (adjust petals in real-time before clamping)
Pressure Distribution	Uneven belt/strap tension	Corner Brass Precision Bolts (consistent multi-point torque)
Material Durability	Can warp, absorb humidity, or harbor mold	Non-porous medical-grade acrylic (easy to sanitize and dry)
Visual Design Experience	Opaque and heavy	Modern elegant tabletop aesthetic (observe curing without opening)

3. Step-by-Step Pressing Protocol

Phase 1: Harvesting & Flower Preparation

- **Harvest at Peak Bloom:** Pick flowers when petals are fully open and vibrant, but before edges begin to dry or turn translucent.
- **Timing is Everything:** Harvest mid-morning on a dry, sunny day after morning dew has completely evaporated (10:00 AM – 11:30 AM). Never press wet or rain-soaked flowers.
- **Trim Stems & Calyxes:** Cut stems flush against the base with sharp floral snips. For bulky flowers (roses, carnations), slice the thick green receptacle in half vertically.

Phase 2: Building the "Drying Sandwich"

The secret to crisp, mold-free botanicals is the 5-layer absorption stack:

[Top Acrylic Press Plate (Crystal Clear)]
├─ [Cardstock Dry Board (Rigid Support)]
├─ [Sponge Paper Layer (Cushions Petal Curves & Distributes Pressure)]
├─ [Blotting Paper Sheet (High-Absorption Moisture Wick)]
| 🌸 [YOUR ARRANGE FLOWER SPECIMENS (0.5" Spacing)] 🌸
├─ [Blotting Paper Sheet]
├─ [Sponge Paper Layer]
├─ [Cardstock Dry Board]
[Bottom Acrylic Press Plate]

SPACING RULE: Leave at least 0.5 inches (1.2 cm) of empty space between flowers on the blotting paper so moisture from neighboring blooms does not cause damp spots.

Phase 3: Tightening & Clamping

- Align the four brass corner bolts through the acrylic plates.
- Hand-tighten all four wing nuts evenly in an **"X" pattern** (top-left, bottom-right, top-right, bottom-left) to distribute pressure symmetrically.

- Tighten until the sponge layers compress firmly—do not overtighten to the point of crushing delicate petals.
- Check the arrangement through the transparent acrylic plate to ensure no petals shifted during tightening.

4. Drying Schedule & Timeline Matrix

FLOWER VARIETY	MOISTURE LEVEL	RECOMMENDED PRESSING TIME	BLOTTER CHANGE REQUIRED?
Pansies, Violas, Johnny Jump-Ups	Low	4 – 7 Days	No
Delphinium, Larkspur, Cosmos	Low	5 – 8 Days	No
Baby's Breath, Lavender, Ferns	Very Low	3 – 5 Days	No
Hydrangeas (Individual Florets)	Medium	7 – 10 Days	Optional at Day 3
Ranunculus, Anemones, Daisies	Medium-High	10 – 14 Days	Yes (Change at Day 3 & Day 7)
Roses (Sliced or Petal-by-Petal)	High	14 – 21 Days	Yes (Change at Day 2, Day 5, Day 10)
Peonies, Dahlias (Dissected Petals)	High	18 – 25 Days	Yes (Change every 3 days)

THE 48-HOUR BLOTTER SWAP RULE: For thick blooms (roses, ranunculus, lilies), open your press after 48 hours and replace the damp blotting paper with fresh dry sheets. This dramatically reduces browning risk and locks in vivid colors.

5. How to Test for 100% Dryness

- **The Touch Test:** Gently touch the center of the bloom with a clean, dry fingertip. It should feel like crisp, delicate parchment or tissue paper. If it feels cool, supple, or damp, clamp it back into the press for another 4–7 days.
- **The Tweezer Lift:** Lift the flower using flat-tip botanical tweezers. A fully cured bloom will remain rigid and horizontal without drooping.

6. Post-Press Finishing, Framing & Display

- **Glass-on-Glass Floating Frames:** Place your arrangement between two panes of UV-filtering glass. Secure petals with microscopic dots of archival, acid-free PVA glue.
- **UV Resin Casting:** Encapsulate pressed blooms in crystal resin for coasters, jewelry, and botanical trays. Ensure flowers are 100% dry before resin pouring.

- **Herbarium Mounting:** Mount specimens on heavy 300gsm acid-free watercolor paper with handwritten botanical classifications.

7. Troubleshooting Common Mistakes

ISSUE	ROOT CAUSE	SOLUTION
Petals turned brown / translucent	Moisture trapped inside or flower was pressed wet	Change blotter paper within first 48 hours; press only dry blooms
Petals stuck to blotting paper	High sugar or nectar content in petals	Use parchment or wax paper liners between bloom and blotter
Colors faded quickly after framing	Exposure to direct sunlight or non-UV glass	Display away from direct sun; use UV-resistant frame glass
Petals wrinkled or curled	Uneven pressure during clamping	Use corner bolt acrylic press; tighten in an X-pattern

The Hwabelle Acrylic Flower Press Kit

Dual crystal-clear acrylic plates (10"x10" Large + 3"x3" Pocket), heavy blotter sheets, compression sponges, and brass hardware.

[Explore the Kit at hwabelle.shop](#)